

Checklist

Managing a Team Checklist

1. Shift from managing individuals to leading a team

- ☐ Treat team management as a different job, not just “more people management.”
- ☐ Spend less time coding, but stay close enough to the work to spot bottlenecks
- ☐ Keep the team focused on the highest-value projects
- ☐ Clear roadblocks that slow the team down
- ☐ Partner closely with product on scope, priorities, and delivery
- ☐ Plan ahead for hiring, headcount, and team needs
- ☐ Set clear expectations for each team member
- ☐ Give frequent feedback, not just during review cycles
- ☐ Communicate timelines, risks, and tradeoffs upward

2. Stay technical

- ☐ Maintain enough hands-on involvement to stay technically credible
- ☐ Guide technical decisions even when others own implementation details
- ☐ Keep enough coding/debugging exposure to feel real bottlenecks firsthand
- ☐ Use your technical judgment to evaluate feasibility and estimates
- ☐ Avoid becoming technically obsolete too early
- ☐ Make time to understand the system, not just the meetings around it

3. Watch for dysfunction on the team

Shipping problems

- ☐ Check whether the team is shipping consistently
- ☐ Look for slow releases, painful deploys, oversized features, or manual testing bottlenecks
- ☐ Push to remove process and tooling bottlenecks
- ☐ Make work small enough to move regularly

People drama

- ☐ Address toxic behavior early
- ☐ Do not let persistent negativity linger
- ☐ Use direct, timely conversations instead of hoping issues resolve themselves
- ☐ Ask for help from your manager when needed

Overwork

- ☐ Look for burnout, instability, or repeated crunch periods
- ☐ Protect time for system stability and sustainability work
- ☐ Support the team visibly during stressful periods
- ☐ Learn from crunch instead of normalizing it

Collaboration problems

- ☐ Check whether the product, design, and partner teams are working well with your team
- ☐ Create regular touchpoints with peers
- ☐ Gather specific feedback about cross-team friction
- ☐ Stay supportive of peers in public

4. Manage former peers carefully

- ☐ Acknowledge the awkwardness of the transition directly
- ☐ Be transparent and ask for their help making the transition work
- ☐ Avoid using managerial power to override technical decisions casually
- ☐ Resist micromanaging people who used to be your peers
- ☐ Pick your battles and protect long-term trust

5. Be a shield, but not a wall

- ☐ Protect the team from unnecessary distraction and politics
- ☐ Give enough context so people understand why goals matter
- ☐ Do not hide everything; share important realities in a calm, low-drama way
- ☐ Communicate clearly during uncertainty so gossip does not fill the gap
- ☐ Treat the team like adults, not children

6. Drive good decisions

- ☐ Accept responsibility for outcomes, even when others own parts of the process
- ☐ Build a data-driven culture for product and technical decisions
- ☐ Track delivery, quality, outages, bugs, and other useful team metrics
- ☐ Develop customer empathy, not just engineering intuition
- ☐ Think ahead about the future roadmap and technical direction
- ☐ Review whether project assumptions actually proved true
- ☐ Run retrospectives on both projects and the team process

7. Handle conflict like a manager

- ☐ Do not rely only on consensus or voting for hard decisions
- ☐ Take responsibility for unpopular decisions when needed
- ☐ Set clear decision-making processes and roles
- ☐ Address simmering issues early
- ☐ Separate problem-solving from gossip and drama
- ☐ Avoid blaming other teams when things go wrong
- ☐ Be kind, not merely “nice.”
- ☐ Notice when fear is making you avoid necessary conversations
- ☐ Get curious about your own conflict avoidance patterns

8. Protect team cohesion

- ☐ Build psychological safety so people can take risks and make mistakes openly
- ☐ Encourage friendliness and trust across the team
- ☐ Watch for people who make others feel unsafe or ineffective
- ☐ Refuse to tolerate destructive behavior from “brilliant jerks.”
- ☐ Address information-hiding and noncommunication quickly
- ☐ Confront the lack of respect toward you or teammates directly
- ☐ Remove persistent toxic behavior if it cannot be corrected

9. Manage projects at the team level

- ☐ Decide which projects to take on and when to push back
- ☐ Plan at a higher level than the team’s day-to-day agile execution
- ☐ Assume less than a full quarter of uninterrupted engineering time

- ☐ Budget roughly 20% for sustaining engineering work
- ☐ Cut scope as deadlines approach
- ☐ Know when to accept a hack and when to insist on the right implementation
- ☐ Use rough estimates carefully; plan more deeply for larger work
- ☐ Shield engineers from constant random estimation requests

10. Onboard yourself into a new team

- ☐ Get a walkthrough of the architecture, systems, release flow, and testing process
- ☐ Learn the codebase enough to talk about real work, not abstractions
- ☐ Plan to work on a couple of features early
- ☐ Watch code reviews and pull requests
- ☐ Participate in support/release work if that is part of the team's responsibilities
- ☐ Build technical credibility through real engagement with the team's work

11. Self-audit questions

- ☐ Have I stopped doing enough old work to make room for management responsibilities?
- ☐ Do I understand the team's day-to-day friction in coding, deploying, and support?
- ☐ Is the team completing work regularly?
- ☐ When was the last time I personally touched the code or paired with someone?
- ☐ Are one or two people driving most of the negativity?
- ☐ Does the team seem engaged with one another?
- ☐ Do we have a clear decision-making process?
- ☐ When did we last review whether a finished project achieved its goals?
- ☐ Does the team understand why it is working on its current projects?
- ☐ When was the last time I cut scope effectively?